

SUBJECT–VERB AGREEMENT

18 Core Rules • Complete Classroom Notes

CBSE Classes 9–10

Rules • 4+ Examples per Rule • Exam Tips • Revision • Practice

What is Subject–Verb Agreement?

Subject–Verb Agreement (also called **Concord**) means that the verb must agree with the subject in **number** and **person**.

Basic Principle: Singular Subject → Singular Verb | Plural Subject → Plural Verb

Subject	Verb Forms	Example
I	am / do / have	I am ready.
You	are / do / have	You are ready.
He / She / It	is / does / has	She has a car.
We / You / They	are / do / have	They have a car.

Quick Tip: In the present tense, he/she/it generally takes a verb ending in **-s/-es**: He **plays**; She **goes**. Plural subjects generally take the base form: They **play**; We **go**.

PART A — Core Agreement Rules

1. Basic Singular & Plural Agreement

A singular subject takes a singular verb, while a plural subject takes a plural verb. This is the starting point for every subject–verb agreement question.

Examples:

He **plays** cricket.

She **is** happy.

They **play** cricket.

We **are** ready.

■ **Remember:** First identify whether the subject is singular or plural.

2. Two Subjects Joined by AND

When two separate subjects are joined by **and**, they generally form a plural subject and take a plural verb.

Examples:

Ram and Shyam **are** friends.

Riya and Priya **have** completed the work.

The teacher and the student **were** present.

My brother and sister **live** in Delhi.

■ **Remember: A + B → plural verb.**

3. OR / NOR / Either...or / Neither...nor

When subjects are joined by **or**, **nor**, **either...or** or **neither...nor**, the verb generally agrees with the subject nearest to it.

Examples:

Either Ram or his friends **are** responsible.

Either his friends or Ram **is** responsible.

Neither the teacher nor the students **were** ready.

Neither the students nor the teacher **was** ready.

■ **Remember: Look at the subject closest to the verb.**

4. Words Between the Subject and the Verb

Do not allow a phrase between the subject and the verb to confuse you. The verb agrees with the main subject, not with a nearby noun.

Examples:

The **quality** of these apples **is** good.

The **box** of chocolates **was** heavy.

The **students** in the classroom **are** studying.

The **list** of names **is** ready.

■ **Remember: Ignore distracting phrases, especially of + noun.**

5. As well as / Along with / Together with

Expressions such as **as well as**, **along with**, **together with** do not change the number of the main subject. The verb agrees with the first subject.

Examples:

Ram, as well as his friends, **is** coming.

The teacher, along with the students, **was** present.

The students, along with their teacher, **were** present.

My father, together with his colleagues, **has** arrived.

■ **Remember: These expressions are not the same as AND.**

PART B — Each, Every, One & Number

6. Each / Every

Each and **every** are followed by a singular noun and take a singular verb.

Examples:

Each student **has** a book.

Every student **is** required to attend.

Each boy **was** ready.

Every child **needs** care.

■ **Remember:** Each / Every → singular verb.

7. Each of / Every one of

After **each of** and **every one of**, the noun is generally plural, but the verb remains singular.

Examples:

Each of the students **is** intelligent.

Each of the players **has** a uniform.

Every one of the boys **was** present.

Each of the books **is** useful.

■ **Remember:** Do not let the plural noun after 'of' change the verb.

8. One of + Plural Noun

The expression **one of + plural noun** takes a singular verb because the grammatical subject is **one**.

Examples:

One of my friends **is** a doctor.

One of the students **has** won the prize.

One of the boys **was** absent.

One of these books **is** mine.

■ **Remember:** One of the students **is** — not 'are'.

9. A Number of / The Number of

A number of + plural noun takes a plural verb. **The number of + plural noun** takes a singular verb.

Examples:

A number of students **are** absent.

A number of people **have** complained.

The number of students **is** increasing.

The number of applicants **has** increased.

■ **Remember:** A number = many → plural; The number = total → singular.

10. Collective Nouns

Collective nouns such as **team, family, committee, class, jury, crowd** usually take a singular verb when the group is treated as one unit.

Examples:

The team **is** winning.

The committee **has** taken a decision.

The family **is** happy.

The class **was** silent.

■ **Remember:** For CBSE-style questions, treat the group as one unit unless the context clearly focuses on individual members.

PART C — Quantity, Special Nouns & There/Here

11. Some / All / Most / Half + of

With expressions such as **some of, all of, most of, half of**, the verb depends on the noun that follows **of**.

Examples:

Some of the water **is** dirty.

Some of the students **are** absent.

Most of the milk **is** spoiled.

Half of the players **are** ready.

■ **Remember:** Check the noun after 'of'.

12. Uncountable Nouns

Uncountable nouns generally take singular verbs. Common examples include **information, advice, furniture, luggage, equipment, news, knowledge, traffic** and **machinery**.

Examples:

The information **is** useful.

His advice **was** helpful.

The furniture **is** expensive.

The news **is** shocking.

■ **Remember:** Do not make an uncountable noun plural just because the meaning is large.

13. Nouns Ending in -s but Singular

Some nouns end in **-s** but are singular in meaning. Important examples are **news, mathematics, physics, economics** and **politics**.

Examples:

The news **is** shocking.

Mathematics **is** interesting.

Physics **is** difficult.

Economics **is** an important subject.

■ **Remember:** The ending '-s' does not always mean plural.

14. Plural-only Nouns & A Pair of

Words such as **scissors, trousers, spectacles, clothes, police** and **cattle** generally take plural verbs. But **a pair of** takes a singular verb.

Examples:

The scissors **are** sharp.

My trousers **are** dirty.

The police **are** investigating.

A pair of scissors **is** on the table.

■ **Remember: Plural-only noun → plural; A pair of → singular.**

15. Amounts of Money, Time, Distance & Weight

When an amount is considered as one complete unit, use a singular verb.

Examples:

Five hundred rupees **is** enough.

Ten kilometres **is** a long distance.

Five years **is** a long time.

Two kilograms **is** enough.

■ **Remember: Think of the amount as one unit.**

16. There / Here

In sentences beginning with **there** or **here**, the verb agrees with the real subject that follows it.

Examples:

There **is** a book on the table.

There **are** many books on the table.

Here **is** your pen.

Here **are** your books.

■ **Remember: Ignore 'there/here' and find the real subject.**

PART D — Special Constructions

17. Gerund as Subject

When an **-ing** form functions as the subject of a sentence, it generally takes a singular verb.

Examples:

Swimming **is** good exercise.

Reading books **is** my hobby.

Playing football **is** enjoyable.

Walking every morning **helps** me stay fit.

■ **Remember:** The whole gerund phrase acts as one subject.

18. Not only...but also

With **not only...but also**, the verb agrees with the subject nearer to the verb.

Examples:

Not only the teacher but also the students **are** responsible.

Not only the students but also the teacher **is** responsible.

Not only Riya but also her friends **have** arrived.

Not only the players but also the captain **was** present.

■ **Remember:** Not only A but also B → verb agrees with B.

QUICK REVISION — 18 RULES AT A GLANCE

No.	Rule / Pattern	Verb
1	Basic singular / plural agreement	According to subject
2	A and B	Plural
3	OR / NOR / Either...or / Neither...nor	Nearest subject
4	Subject + intervening phrase	Main subject
5	As well as / Along with / Together with	First subject
6	Each / Every	Singular
7	Each of / Every one of + plural noun	Singular
8	One of + plural noun	Singular
9	A number of / The number of	Plural / Singular
10	Collective noun as one unit	Usually singular
11	Some / All / Most / Half + of	Depends on noun after 'of'
12	Uncountable nouns	Singular
13	News / Mathematics / Physics / Economics	Singular
14	Scissors / trousers / police / A pair of	Plural / Singular
15	Money / time / distance / weight as one unit	Singular
16	There is / There are; Here is / Here are	Following subject
17	Gerund as subject	Singular
18	Not only A but also B	Nearest subject

COMMON CBSE EXAM TRAPS

Question	Correct	Reason
The quality of the apples ____ good.	is	Subject = quality
Ram, along with his friends, ____ coming.	is	Main subject = Ram
Each of the boys ____ a book.	has	Each = singular
One of the students ____ absent.	is	One = singular
A number of students ____ absent.	are	A number = many
The number of students ____ increasing.	is	The number = total
Some of the water ____ dirty.	is	Water = uncountable
Some of the students ____ absent.	are	Students = plural
The news ____ shocking.	is	News = singular
Mathematics ____ interesting.	is	Mathematics = singular
The scissors ____ sharp.	are	Scissors = plural-only
A pair of scissors ____ on the table.	is	A pair = singular
There ____ many books here.	are	Subject = books
Half of the students ____ absent.	are	Students = plural
Half of the work ____ complete.	is	Work = uncountable

GOLDEN RULES — REMEMBER THESE

- ① Find the **real subject** before choosing the verb.
- ② Ignore nouns inside phrases such as **of, along with, as well as, together with**.
- ③ **A and B → plural.**
- ④ **Either/Neither/Or/Nor → nearer subject.**
- ⑤ **Each / Every / One of → singular.**
- ⑥ **A number of → plural; The number of → singular.**
- ⑦ With **some/all/most/half of**, check the noun after **of**.
- ⑧ **There is/are → check the subject after the verb.**
- ⑨ **Not only...but also → nearer subject.**

PRACTICE EXERCISE

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1. Each of the students _____ (has/have) submitted the assignment. | 2. The quality of these products _____ (is/are) excellent. |
| 3. A number of students _____ (is/are) absent today. | 4. The number of applicants _____ (has/have) increased. |
| 5. Neither the teacher nor the students _____ (was/were) ready. | 6. Neither the students nor the teacher _____ (was/were) ready. |
| 7. Mathematics _____ (is/are) my favourite subject. | 8. The scissors _____ (is/are) on the table. |
| 9. One of the boys _____ (has/have) won the prize. | 10. There _____ (is/are) many books on the shelf. |
| 11. Everyone _____ (is/are) invited. | 12. The team _____ (is/are) playing well. |

13. Ten kilometres _____ (is/are) a long distance.

14. Half of the students _____ (is/are) absent.

15. Half of the work _____ (is/are) complete.

16. Ram, along with his friends, _____ (is/are) coming.

17. Either the teacher or the students _____ (is/are) responsible.

18. Either the students or the teacher _____ (is/are) responsible.

19. Not only the teacher but also the students _____ (is/are) responsible.

20. Reading books _____ (is/are) a good habit.

ANSWER KEY

1	has	2	is	3	are	4	has	5	were
6	was	7	is	8	are	9	has	10	are
11	is	12	is	13	is	14	are	15	is
16	is	17	are	18	is	19	are	20	is

FINAL MEMORY TRICK: Find the Subject → Ignore Distractions → Apply the Rule → Check the Verb.